PassFrame
TUITION

Mary Anning: Fossil Hunter

Year 4 — 11+ Homework Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Non-fiction (Biography)

Extract — read it carefully before answering

Mary Anning was born in 1799 in the small seaside town of Lyme Regis, England — a place famous even then for the strange, stony shapes that washed out of its crumbling cliffs after every storm. Her family was poor, and from a young age Mary helped collect and sell these curiosities to earn money.

What nobody realised at first was that these "curiosities" were actually fossils — the remains of creatures that had lived millions of years earlier, long before any human walked the Earth. Mary had an extraordinary talent for spotting fossils that others walked straight past.

When Mary was just twelve years old, she made a discovery that would change the course of science: the complete skeleton of an ichthyosaur, a huge sea creature with a long snout and enormous eyes, unlike anything scientists had ever properly studied before.

Despite her remarkable discoveries, Mary faced great difficulty being taken seriously. Women were not allowed to join the Geological Society at the time, and many of the male scientists who bought her fossils took the credit for finding them, rarely mentioning her name in their published work.

Today, however, Mary Anning is recognised as one of the most important fossil hunters in history. Her discoveries helped shape our early understanding of prehistoric life, and scientists still study specimens she found over two hundred years ago.

Questions

25 min · 12 questions

1. What was special about the cliffs near Mary's hometown?

2. What word does the text use to describe the fossils before people understood what they were?

3. Underline the sentence that tells you Mary's family was not wealthy.

4. Underline the sentence that explains why women faced difficulty in science at the time.

5. What does "remarkable" mean as it is used to describe Mary's discoveries?

6. Put these events in order: Mary finds the ichthyosaur skeleton / Mary is recognised as an important historical figure / Mary's family sells fossils to earn money / male scientists take credit for Mary's finds.

7. Why might the author have described Lyme Regis as "famous for the strange, stony shapes" that washed from its cliffs?

8. How old was Mary when she made her famous ichthyosaur discovery?

9. Why do you think it took so long for Mary to be properly recognised for her work?

10. What does the phrase "scientists still study specimens she found" suggest about the lasting value of Mary's work?

11. Find and copy a word that means "things valued for being rare, strange or interesting".

12. Write one or two sentences explaining why you think Mary Anning's story is still told today.